PERSUASION SPEECH FORMAL OUTLINE

DANIEL BURGER

6-8 minutes

TOPIC: NEGATIVE SELF-TALK

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To persuade my audience to work on avoiding negative self-talk for the benefit of their mental health.

THESIS STATEMENT: The way we speak to and about ourselves matters, and working to change this bad habit can be beneficial for our self-esteem, emotional regulation, and even mental and physical performance.

INTRODUCTION (1 minute)

[ATTENTION]

Attention getter: "I'm such an idiot," "I'm the worst," "I'm an awful person," — these are all examples of "negative self-talk" – something many of us are guilty of to some degree.

Thesis statement: The way we speak to and about ourselves matters, and working to change this bad habit can be beneficial for our self-esteem, emotional regulation, and even mental and physical performance.

Credibility/preview: I have struggled with my mental health for years, and especially with negative self-talk. I have been in therapy for several years working on this, and hope that the perspective I can bring will be helpful, so that you too can learn why negative self-talk is an issue, understand the benefits to changing this behavior, and know the steps to improve this unhelpful type of thinking.

BODY (4-6 minutes; 1.3-2 minutes per point?)

[PROBLEM/NEED]

1. Negative self-talk has a negative effect on our self-esteem and mental health
    a. Self-talk affects our self-esteem, which in turn affects our mental health and relationships. (UK National Institute of Health, 2023)
    b. Negative self-talk also affects our performance (Hardy, Roberts, & Hardy, 2009)

[SOLUTION/SATISFACTION]

2. Negative self-talk can be improved (Rivernorth Counseling, 2026)
    a. STEP 1: Recognize the negative thought as it happens
    b. STEP 2: Ask yourself: is this true? Is this fair?
    c. STEP 3: Reframe the thought in a true but gentle way.

[VISUALIZATION]

3. Taking steps to work on negative self-talk can have great effects on mental health
    a. Self-acceptance talk has been proven to improve focus and emotional regulation (Racy & Morin, 2024)

CONCLUSION (1 minute?)

[ACTION]

Restated thesis / re-summary: How we speak to ourselves makes a difference in our lives and our mental health, and making changes to be aware of these negative thoughts, evaluate if they are true, and attempting to be kinder to ourselves will greatly improve our self-esteem and thus improve our lives.

Final statement:

It is my hope that with this knowledge and perspective, you will be able to improve your own experiences with negative self-talk. In the words of Christine Arylo: "**"Be nice to yourself... It's hard to be happy when someone is mean to you all the time."**

Bibliography

Hardy, J., Roberts, R., & Hardy, L. (2009). Awareness and Motivation to Change Negative Self-Talk. *Sports Psychologist*, 435-450.

Racy, F., & Morin, A. (2024). Relationships between Self-Talk, Inner Speech, Mind Wandering, Mindfulness, Self-Concept Clarity, and Self-Regulation in University Students. *Behavioral Sciences*, 1, 8-9.

Rivernorth Counseling. (2026, April 8). *How to Stop Negative Self-Talk and Build Self-Respect*. Retrieved from Rivernorth Counseling: https://www.rivernorthcounseling.com/counseling/how-to-stop-negative-self-talk-and-build-self-respect/

UK National Institute of Health. (2023, April). *Raising low self-esteem*. Retrieved from NHS: https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/tips-and-support/raise-low-self-esteem/